

Chapter 12

The Things You Were Never Told

The room was quiet.

Elara sat beside the window, staring at the city lights outside.

She hadn't moved for a long time.

Her father's words kept replaying in her mind.

It's business.

She closed her eyes.

No matter how hard she tried, she couldn't convince herself that it was just business.

Her father had known what Roman meant to her.

Ethan had known.

And yet...

they had both kept things from her.

Elara reached for the book beside her and opened it.

She tried to read.

But the words blurred together.

Her phone suddenly vibrated on the bedside table.

She looked toward it.

For a moment...

she didn't move.

Then she reached for her phone.

The screen lit up.

Roman Ashford

Her heart skipped.

She opened the message.

Roman:

We need to talk.

Elara stared at it.

Her fingers slowly moved across the keyboard.

Elara:

About what?

She pressed send.

Across the city...

Roman sat alone in his apartment.

His phone rested in his hand.

The lights of Frankfurt reflected across the windows behind him.

He had been staring at Elara's contact for several minutes.

There were things he wanted to say.

Things he had wanted to say for a long time.

But he knew a message could never explain everything.

His phone vibrated.

Elara:

About what?

Roman typed slowly.

Roman:

About the things you were never told.

He pressed send.

Elara's phone vibrated again.

She opened the message.

Roman:

About the things you were never told.

Her expression changed.

She typed:

Elara:

And why should I trust you?

Roman replied almost immediately.

Roman:

You don't have to.

A second message appeared.

Roman:

I'll send you the location.

A location appeared in the chat.

Veyron Tower, Private Rooftop

Elara stared at it.

She didn't know what Roman wanted to tell her.

But she knew she couldn't keep avoiding the questions forever.

She stood.

Picked up her coat.
Then grabbed her car keys.
Before leaving, she stopped in front of the mirror.
Her eyes looked tired.
"Just listen."
She whispered.
"Nothing more."

A few minutes later...
Elara sat inside her car.
The engine was still off.
She stared through the windshield.
Her phone was still in her hand.
She looked at Roman's name.
Then took a slow breath.
"It's just a conversation."
She started the car.

The roads were busy that evening.
Elara drove through the city.
Her thoughts kept drifting.
Then traffic suddenly slowed.
A delivery truck had broken down across one lane.
Cars were barely moving.
Elara looked at the time.
"Great."
She leaned back against the seat.
For a few minutes...
she simply waited.
Eventually, the traffic started moving again.
She followed the alternate route toward Veyron Tower.

When she finally arrived...
Elara parked the car.

But she didn't get out immediately.
She sat there quietly.
Her hand rested on the steering wheel.
Then she looked at the building.
After a long breath...
she stepped out.

The elevator doors opened onto the rooftop.
Elara stepped outside.
The evening air was cool.
Frankfurt stretched beneath her.
Roman was standing near the edge of the rooftop.
He turned when he heard the door.
Their eyes met.
Elara walked toward him.
"You said we needed to talk."
Roman nodded.
"We do."
"Then talk."
Her voice was steady.
Roman looked at her.
"I know you have questions."
"I have more than questions."
"I know."
Elara looked away.
Then suddenly...
her expression changed.
"Do you even know what you've done to me?"
Roman remained silent.
Elara continued.
"When I saw you in that library..."
Her voice became quieter.
"I thought I was seeing a ghost."
Roman's expression hardened.

"Elara..."

"No."

She shook her head.

"Let me speak."

Roman said nothing.

Elara looked down at her hands.

"Do you know how long it's been since that night?"

Roman watched her carefully.

"Three months."

Her voice trembled slightly.

"Three months since you messaged me from an unknown number."

"Three months since I started wondering whether everything I believed was actually true."

She took a breath.

"Since that day..."

"I haven't been sleeping properly."

Roman's expression changed.

Elara looked toward the city.

"I joined the office because I thought keeping myself busy would make things easier."

A bitter smile appeared on her face.

"What did I know?"

She looked back at him.

"I had no idea you were written into my life again."

Roman remained completely still.

"You can't imagine what I'm facing right now."

Her eyes became wet.

"The people I trusted..."

She paused.

"They broke that trust."

"My father."

"Ethan."

"Everyone I believed."

Her voice cracked.

"And now you're standing in front of me telling me that everything I believed about you might be wrong."

Roman took a slow breath.

"I know it's a lot."

"No."

Elara shook her head.

"You don't know."

She wiped her tears quickly.

"You can't."

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Roman quietly said,

"Then tell me what you need."

Elara looked at him.

"I don't know."

Her voice was almost a whisper.

"I honestly don't know what I'm supposed to do."

She looked down.

"I don't have the strength for this right now."

Roman took a small step toward her.

But stopped.

He didn't want to make her uncomfortable.

"You don't have to decide anything tonight."

Elara looked at him.

"I thought I hated you."

Roman said nothing.

"I spent so much time believing you were responsible."

Her voice trembled.

"And now..."

She looked away.

"I don't even know what I feel anymore."

Roman remained silent.

Elara took a deep breath.

"I can't help you."

Roman nodded slowly.

"I understand."

"I can't promise to trust you."

"You don't have to."

"I can't promise I'll believe you."

"I know."

She looked at him one last time.

"I just need time."

Roman nodded.

"Take all the time you need."

Elara turned toward the door.

She stopped for a moment.

Without looking back, she said,

"I came here because I wanted answers."

A pause.

"But right now..."

"I don't even know which questions to ask."

Then she walked away.

Roman watched her disappear through the glass door.

He didn't follow.

He didn't call her back.

He simply stood there...

knowing that for now,

the only thing he could give her was time.